me from sufferings that had now become intolerable. I descended to the roadside determined to declare myself to the first Afghans who approached and court the blow of some pitying sword. I saw a party approach, and concluded the hour of my death had arrived.

But the party proved to be five Hindu Khatris,[hh] or traders:

These Cutries said, 'As you are a Hindoo, we will save your life, but you must pay us before doing so.' They searched me and took the 100 rupees out of my cummerbund, and returned me ten of them – they conducted me to a dharamasala [pilgrims' resthouse] in which there was a Hindoo Fakir. His protection I also sought, and gave him my remaining ten rupees. He dressed me up in the red dress of a fakir and rubbed wood ashes over my face. I was to pass for his chela [disciple]; and he said I was to accompany him in the character of such on a pilgrimage he proposed making to Hardwar. A party of fruit merchants shortly after arrived. The fakir, the Cutries and myself joined them. We descended the high road considerably to the left of Peshawar. I begged my way until I got to Sir Jasper Nicholls's Camp, one march this side of Ludhiana.[59]

The least lucky were those hundreds of sepoys and camp followers who neither escaped nor were enslaved or killed. In the Tezin Pass alone, 1,500 of these were stripped of their goods and their clothes by the Afghans, then left to starve and freeze to death in the snows, abandoned by their British employers and treated with contempt by their Afghan captors.[60] Lady Sale and the other prisoners of war saw many such in the days that followed, as they headed back towards Kabul. 'The road was covered with awful mangled bodies, all naked,' wrote Lady Sale in her diary.

We passed some 200 dead bodies, many of them Europeans, the whole naked, and covered with large gaping wounds . . . Numbers of camp followers, we found still alive, frostbitten and starving; some perfectly out of their senses and idiotic . . . The sight was dreadful; the smell of blood sickening; and the corpses lay so thick that it was impossible to look upon them as it required care to guide my horse so as not to tread upon the bodies.

They came upon several camp followers who emerged from caves or from behind rocks 'where they had taken shelter from the murderous knives of the Affghan and the inclemency of the climate'.

They had been stripped of all they possessed, and few could crawl more than a few yards on hands and knees, being frostbitten in the feet. Here Johnson found two of his servants: the one had his hands and feet frostbitten, and had a fearful swordcut across one hand, and a musketball in his stomach: the other had his right arm completely cut through the bone. Both were utterly destitute of covering, and had not tasted food for five days . . . Wounded and starving, they had set fire to the bushes and grass, and huddled all together to impart warmth to each other.